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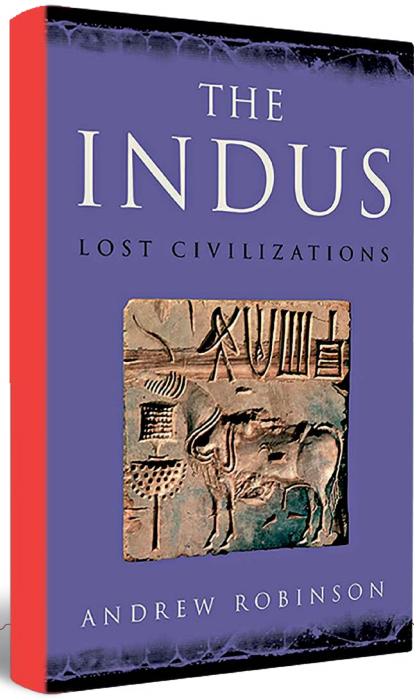
SHOULD BE ON YOUR READING LIST



VIKRAM AND VETALA: A Transformative Retelling
By Douglas J. Penick
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 240 pages

DEAD MAN TALKING

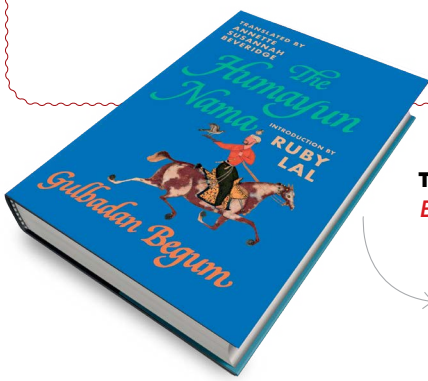
Douglas J. Penick's retelling of the 25 tales in the *Baital Pachchisi* not only recounts King Vikramaditya's well-known ordeal—where he has to answer a riddle posed by a corpse-spirit (Vetala) he is carrying or face unimaginable consequences—but he also weaves in the Vetala's origin story, besides adding an overarching narrative arc and a conclusion that ties everything together neatly. Penick has previously written an opera about the Emperor Ashoka and theatre pieces based on *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, among other literary works. The introduction by Namita Gokhale delineates the position these stories have in ancient Indian tradition.



THE INDUS
Lost Civilizations
By Andrew Robinson
MACMILLAN
₹399; 208 pages

REMEMBRANCE OF THINGS PAST

A prolific writer and Indophile, Andrew Robinson has written about everything from Satyajit Ray to Rabindranath Tagore, maharajas, Indian history, undeciphered scripts and, well, the Indus Valley civilisation. The book is not new, having been published previously in the UK. But this is the first Indian edition of what is, perhaps, one of the best short introductions on the subject. It's part of the 'Lost Civilizations' series, which explores the rise and fall of the world's great civilisations and their relevance in contemporary times.



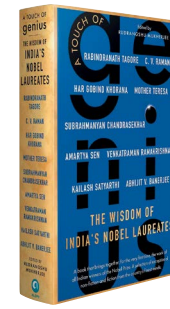
THE HUMAYUN NAMA
By Gulbadan Begum
Translated by Annette Susannah Beveridge
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 408 pages

AN EMPEROR'S TALE

This biography of the emperor Humayun by his sister Gulbadan Begum is, we are told, the only surviving work of Mughal history by a royal woman. Combined with the writer's front-row access to seminal events and court intrigues makes it a fascinating document. This annotated scholarly edition of Annette Susannah Beveridge's 1902 translation of the *Humayun Nama* has a new introduction—which sets the context beautifully—by scholar Ruby Lal, who authored *Vagabond Princess*, a biography of Gulbadan, a couple of years ago.

Wise Words

For the first time, a book brings together the selected writings of Indian Nobel laureates, including naturalised Indians and erstwhile citizens. That's nine people, ranging from Rabindranath Tagore (the 1913 winner) to, most recently, Abhijit Banerjee (2019). The book is divided into sections like 'Memoir', 'Literature', 'Science', 'Politics' and, of course, 'Nobel Lectures'.



A TOUCH OF GENIUS
The Wisdom of India's Nobel Laureates
Edited by Rudrangshu Mukherjee
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹1,499; 848 pages

—Compiled by Amit Dixit